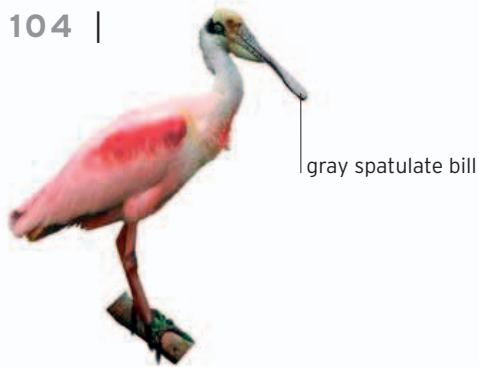




Roseate spoonbill

Platalea ajaja

The only spoonbill in the Americas, of six species worldwide, the roseate is also the world's only pink spoonbill. It has the hallmark long, thick, flattened bill that broadens out into a round tip or "spoon." When feeding, the spoonbill sweeps its bill, partly open, from side to side through shallow water; the bill snaps shut when small fish, water beetles, shrimp, or snails touch the sensitive nerve endings inside the spoon. Nostrils located at the base of the bill help the bird breathe with its bill immersed. Roseate spoonbills feed in rivermouths, mangrove swamps, and freshwater marshes inland, often with other wading birds.

Colonial nesters

Breeding pairs nest in mixed-species colonies in nearby mangroves, trees, or reeds. Both sexes incubate between one and five eggs, which hatch after 22–24 days. The chicks' bills are initially short, straight, and soft, only becoming spoon-shaped after nine days. Both parents feed and protect the chicks, which are never left alone. They beg noisily and reach inside the parent's open bill to take regurgitated food. The young take off on their first flight at six weeks old, and can fly well at seven or eight weeks.

- ↔ 28–33 in (70–85 cm)
- ⚖ 3 lb (1.4 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🐟 Fish, crustaceans, mollusks
- 🏠 

S. North
America,
Caribbean,
South America



△ COURTSHIP RITUAL

Waving their wings and grasping bill tips, roseate spoonbills perform a courtship dance on the ground, in water, or even high in a tree.

long legs ideal
for wading

▷ STUNNING COLORS

Certain crustaceans in the roseate spoonbill's diet feed on algae that have carotenoid pigments, giving the bird its striking pink color.

color varies
with diet

white neck stays
outstretched
in flight